Hockey was a new sport to me but I was included in the B side, learned the rules, scored a few goals and, three weeks later, was selected for the Under-16A side. We had a strong team and a successful season, including a first-ever win by an Affies hockey team over an equivalent side at Pretoria Boys' High. Our near neighbours were traditionally stronger in hockey but, after many years when our A side was considered only good enough to play their B or C sides, our Under-16As were given the opportunity to play As against As, and we won.

One year of hockey was great, but one year of hockey was also enough. For my last two years at Affies, I decided to return to rugby and try again to succeed in the sport that mattered most at our school.

Nothing would come easy. I trained hard and tried to impress but, when the 1st teams of the season were put up on the noticeboard, I was chosen to play flyhalf for the 5th XV. Fair enough, I thought. Then, out of the blue, midway through the year, a couple of guys were injured and I was invited to play at 10 for the 3rd XV. Mr Potgieter, the 2nd XV coach, happened to see me play and liked what he saw.

'De Villiers,' he said, 'I would like you to join the 2nd XV training squad.'

At last, this was the break.

Our next fixture was the derby against Boys' High. It felt like the most important match of my entire life and, catapulted into playing flyhalf for the 2nd XV, I managed to make a few decent breaks and to kick seven out of seven attempts at the posts. It was a great day, and we stormed to a wonderful 40–0 victory.

'How did the first team get on?'

'They won ... just,' came the reply.

People were saying that Sarel Potgieter, one of our star players, was playing out of position at 10 and wanted to move to centre, but there was no obvious alternative at flyhalf. The whispering and speculation started. Literally, in the space of three weeks, I had been brought in from